



Frisking the Chiefs

DELHI They are entrusted with the task of securing the country's borders, but at the many airports of India, the three service chiefs are still not exempt from body frisking and other security checks. Now, Aviation Minister Praful Patel is planning to extend this civil courtesy to the three chiefs.

The matter was raised in Parliament last week by Rajya Sabha member from Karnataka Rajeev Chandrasekhar who wanted to know why the chiefs were not accorded

a privilege which was given to politicians, ambassadors and bureaucrats. In a written reply to the question, Defence Minister A.K. Antony had stated that according to the Aviation Ministry, the chiefs could not be included in this list since "it would lead to similar demands from some other authorities".

However, Patel seems to have done a rethink since. He told INDIA TODAY, "I am inclined to exempt the three service chiefs and will take this matter

CIVILITY: Service chiefs may be exempt from security checks at airports up with the requisite committee. In due process, I am sure it will be done." Following Antony's rejection of his demands, Chandrasekhar had also written to Patel saying that "the position, stature and respect accorded to the three service chiefs is unique and not comparable to any similar demand from any other authority".

The exempted list goes according to the warrant of precedence issued by Rashtrapati Bhavan. The chiefs figure at number 12 on this list whereas the exemption stops at number 10 and includes the President, the prime minister, Cabinet ministers, Supreme Court judges and members of the Gandhi family. The list is cleared by an inter-ministerial committee.

After the matter was highlighted in the upper House, it seems as if the Government may take another look at an age-old policy and give the three service chiefs a hassle-free ride as well.

by Priya Sahgal

SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: Mumbai's Archbishop **Oswald Gracias** as the Cardinal of India, by the Vatican. He is the only Asian among the 23 newly-elected cardinals.

SURPASSED: Australian Alan Border by **Sachin Tendulkar**, who broke his record of 11,174 runs in



Test cricket. He is now only behind West Indies' Brian Lara's 11,953 runs.

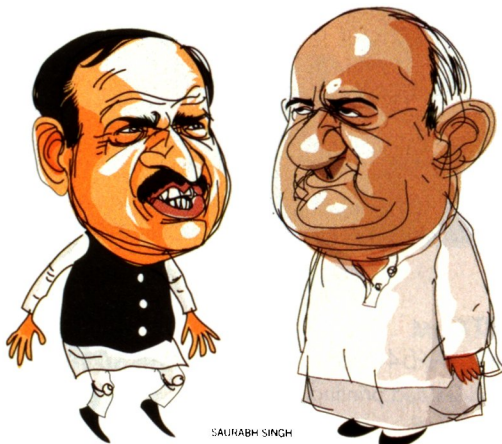
GRANTED: Bail to actor **Sanjay Dutt**, by the Supreme Court, who is in jail in connection with the 1993 Mumbai blasts.

AWARDED: To danseuse and activist **Shallu Jindal**, the Indira Gandhi Priyadarshini Award 2007, for her contribution to classical dance, national integration and women empowerment.

WON: By **Dola Banerjee**, the gold medal in the Archery World Cup in Dubai. She beat Korea's Choi Eun Young.

VIS-A-VIS ANANTH KUMAR BJP leader versus H.D. DEVE GOWDA JD(S) chief

“
Sheer lust for power led Deve Gowda to withdraw support to the coalition government in Karnataka. He is a betrayer.”



“
I do not want a certificate from any political outfit. A former Karnataka chief minister tried to destabilise my party.”

EPILOGUE: After his somersault, Gowda would be lucky if the voters don't hand him an exit certificate.